



Highlight

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Front and Center

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Front and Center

Mobile has been a space that has seen massive growth in the last few years, influencing nearly every sphere of technology, society, media and even the government. It has changed the way we communicate through internet-enabled phones, led to development of energy efficient microprocessors and has led to the creation of an entire field - big data and data mining. Another space that is seeing massive growth is 3D printing, or the ability to manufacture a 3D product inexpensively using a 2D design specification.

We examine these trends in some detail, for these are technologies that deserve a second glance.

Messaging Apps to replace SMS (SMS 2.0?)

One of the hottest spaces in mobile right now is messaging, an area that has companies both big and small trying to make their presence felt. While the venerable SMS certainly isn't going anywhere, mobile messaging apps that use a device's data connection to send text and multimedia are fast becoming the norm, with users welcoming these SMS replacements with open arms. Cheaper data plans, a rapidly rising number of internet-connected devices coupled with mobile carriers charging exorbitant rates for SMS, has aided the adoption of services like Whatsapp, Kik, Line and Viber. Not to be left behind, tech giants have stepped up their offerings - Apple has iMessage, Microsoft has Skype, Facebook revamped its Mes-

senger app and Google unified all its chat services under the name "Hangouts".

With several apps vying for a slice of the messaging pie, the fragmentation of the messaging ecosystem is becoming a cause of worry. While SMS was an open, ubiquitous standard - anyone with a mobile phone was guaranteed to be able to send and receive messages, the same is not true with messaging apps. Both the sender and the receiver need to be signed in to the same app in order to communicate, and keeping track of which of your friends are on which service can quickly turn frustrating.

In practice, very interesting trends have emerged. Different services have managed to capture users in different regions of the world, with the lack of any one service dominating globally. Whatsapp, possibly the largest messaging apps in terms of number of users (Whatsapp recently reported they have more users than Twitter) as well as revenue (What-